comfortably distant, had to be reconciled with a modern India which had become a ‘slave nation’ under the British and a launch pad for the latter’s depredations against China. Ancient India could be an inspiration and even worthy of reverence. India under the British became an object of pity and derision, a teacher by negative example for China, as we shall see in Chapter 14.

~

While India may have entered the Chinese imagination, in particular through the spread of Buddhism, there is almost no sign of China having registered in the Indian consciousness through its long history. It is only in the modern period that China emerged on the Indian radar screen, and despite a recognition of its impact on India and on Asia as a whole, little effort was made in India to become familiar with the country, its culture, its way of thinking and its world view. This continued even after Indian independence in 1947.

According to Chinese historical records, during the first millennium there may have been about 3,000 Indian monks and teachers who travelled to China to propagate their faith. Most appear to have made China their permanent home. While they left behind extensive translations in Chinese of Buddhist scriptures, there are no extant accounts of their impressions of the country they had made their home, nor of people they came in contact with. Perhaps these accounts exist but they have not been discovered as of now. By contrast, several Chinese pilgrims and even envoys who travelled to India during this period, such as Fa Xian, Xuan Zang or the general Wang Xuance, left behind extensive accounts of the country they visited and the lives of its inhabitants. But for these accounts, our knowledge and understanding of ancient India would have been sparse or altogether a blank.

Liezi is a Taoist text attributed to Lie Yukou, a fifth-century bce philosopher.

A sutra is a collection of aphorisms collated on palm leaves or paper strung together by a string, hence ‘sutra’, or ‘string’. The Sutra of 42 Sections was a collection of sayings ascribed to the Buddha.